

SITE NF-7 CERAMIC ASSEMBLAGE - PRELIMINARY ANALYSIS REPORT

North Frisian Medieval Wreck Survey | DFG GR 4471/3

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1. Introduction

This report presents a preliminary analysis of the nine ceramic objects and fragments recovered during the Phase 3 excavation season (June-August 2025) at Site NF-7, North Frisian Islands. The assemblage supplements the four ceramic items recovered during Phase 2 (2024) and provides a more complete basis for discussion of the vessel's cargo, date, and trade connections.

The analysis draws on established typologies for late medieval North Sea ceramics, particularly the Langerwehe-Raeren stoneware sequence, Siegburg production, and the southern North Sea greyware tradition. Comparanda are drawn from excavated assemblages at Hamburg, Lubeck, Dordrecht, and from published shipwreck contexts in the North Sea and Baltic.

2. Catalogue of Phase 3 Ceramic Finds

Find No.	Object	Material	Depth (m)	Context	Provisional date
NF7-031	Jug handle	Langerwehe stoneware	12-13	Cargo scatter	1350-1420
NF7-038	Jug body fragment	Langerwehe stoneware	12-13	Cargo scatter	1350-1420
NF7-042	Jar rim	Siegburg stoneware	13-14	Cargo	1300-1380
NF7-057	Pitcher base	Greyware, regional	12-13	Cargo scatter	1300-1400
NF7-058	Bowl rim fragment	Greyware, regional	12-13	Secondary scatter	1280-1380
NF7-061	Storage jar body	Greyware, coarse	13-14	Hull context	1250-1400
NF7-067	Jug neck fragment	Langerwehe stoneware	12-13	Cargo scatter	1350-1420
NF7-074	Pottery sherd	Greyware, reduced	13-14	Secondary scatter	1280-1380
NF7-081	Small vessel base	Fine white stoneware	12-13	Hull context	1350-1420

3. Typological Analysis

Langerwehe and Raeren Stoneware (NF7-031, NF7-038, NF7-067)

Three fragments are consistent with production at Langerwehe, in the Eifel region near Aachen, on the basis of fabric colour, surface treatment, and wall thickness. The jug handle from NF7-031 has a pronounced thumb impression at the upper terminal, a characteristic technique in Langerwehe production of the later 14th century. The fabric is a mid-grey with characteristic orange-tan inclusions visible in fresh break. Similar material has been identified in Hamburg harbour excavations (layer sequence 1370-1420) and in the Rotterdam shipwreck finds published by van Dongen (1993).

Siegburg Stoneware (NF7-042)

The jar rim from NF7-042 presents the smooth, pale, near-white fabric and low-temperature reduction firing characteristic of Siegburg production. The form is consistent with storage function and the rim profile matches published examples dated to the third quarter of the 14th century. Siegburg ware was widely distributed through Hanseatic networks and its presence at NF-7 supports a northern German or Low Countries origin for the vessel's trade route.

Regional Greyware (NF7-057, NF7-058, NF7-061, NF7-074)

Four fragments represent the broad regional greyware tradition of the southern and eastern North Sea. The coil-built construction visible in NF7-061 and the temper composition of all four fragments suggest a production zone somewhere in the lower Rhine or Weser area. This is consistent with the cargo profile expected of a vessel operating on the Hamburg-to-Frisian-coast or Hamburg-to-Netherlands circuit, the most heavily travelled routes of the 14th-century Hanseatic network in this region.

4. Dating and Interpretation

The ceramic evidence supports a vessel date in the second half of the 14th century, most likely within the range 1350 to 1420. This is consistent with the Phase 2 dating estimate based on nail morphology and the clinker plank construction technique. The assemblage is not large enough to refine this range further without additional finds, but the presence of Langerwehe ware argues against a date earlier than 1350, and the absence of later Raeren products suggests the vessel was lost before Raeren production achieved its peak regional distribution after approximately 1440.

The combination of Langerwehe, Siegburg, and regional greyware is consistent with a cargo assembled in the Hamburg or lower Elbe area for distribution to Frisian and Jutland coastal markets. This route is attested in 14th-century customs records and fits the geographic position of NF-7 as a vessel in transit rather than a vessel at anchor.

5. Comparanda

The NF-7 ceramic assemblage invites comparison with a small number of published medieval wrecks from the North Sea region. The Doel 1 wreck from the Scheldt estuary (dated to around 1325) shares the regional greyware profile, though its Langerwehe component is less pronounced, suggesting an earlier date or a slightly more western trade route. The Burgzand Noord 10 wreck (Netherlands) shows the Langerwehe-Raeren overlap characteristic of the late 14th century, though its assemblage is far richer and suggests a larger or more valuable cargo.

Within German waters, comparanda from the Lubeck harbour excavations and from the Wismar bay investigations provide a useful regional framework, though both contexts are harbour rather than open-water depositions. The closest parallel in terms of composition and context may be the Ystad cargo published by Goran Wallentin (1998), which shows a similar Langerwehe and regional greyware combination from a vessel that appears to have been engaged in the Denmark-to-Hamburg route in the period 1360-1400.

6. Further Work

The preliminary dating and trade-network interpretation presented here should be tested against the dendrochronology results expected from Caledonia Maritime University in early 2026, and against the complete Phase 3 finds catalogue once desalination and treatment of the iron assemblage is complete. A comparative fabric analysis of the greyware fragments using portable X-ray fluorescence would help clarify the production zone more precisely and is recommended as a Phase 4 analytical objective.

The nine Phase 3 ceramic finds and the four Phase 2 ceramic finds will be published together as part of the NF-7 finds catalogue, which is in preparation as Appendix C of the forthcoming monograph "Hanseatic Routes Beneath the German Bight" (draft target spring 2027).

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